Refugee Movements: Czechoslovakia & The Soviet Union - A History

1948

Pressure from the Czechoslovakian Communist Party forced President Edvard Benes to allow a Communist government to form. Western observers viewed the Communists taking power to be an expression of Soviet expansion into Eastern Europe.

1968

On January 5th, Alexander Dubček became the first secretary of the Czechoslovak Communist Party.

1968

Dubček began implementing liberal reforms, including freedom of the press. Offering "socialism with a human face", Dubček planned to democratise the government further, as well as create a constitution which guaranteed civic rights and liberties.

1968

The Soviet Union and other Warsaw Pact countries viewed his changes as counterrevolutionary. On August 20th, Soviet armed forces invaded Czechoslovakia with 500,000 troops. Those who defended their freedom of expression were killed. The death toll rose to 72.

1968

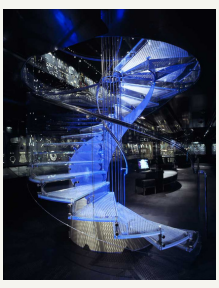
300,000 Czechs fled. The rest were forced to live under an oppressive regime. Many fled to the United Kingdom, United States, and 12,000 resettled in Canada.

1968

Eva Jiřičná was an exchange student for the Greater London Council. The Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia meant she was barred from returning to Czechoslovakia that same year. Jiřičná cited her political views, such as membership to the Society for the Protection of Human Rights, as the reason behind the decision.

1969

Just a year later, Jiřičná was made an associate architect at the Louis de Soissons Partnership. In 1980, she founded her own architecture company. Her fusion of interior and architectural design has been widely influential, being displayed in the V&A museum and earning her a CBE.



1990

Jiřičná was finally able to return to Czechoslovakia after 22 years. However, Czechoslovakia was a changed place. For Jiřičná, “the biggest loss [was]...Wenceslas Square...one of the most beautiful urban places".